

the need to market these products, distinguish one product from the other and generate interest in the buying community.

Shopping has had a huge change of outlook since the oncoming of e-commerce, or online shopping platforms. Though popularised by Jeff Bezos with Amazon, e-commerce quickly became the trend in the Indian shopping space as well. Since the introduction of internet in 1995 in India, sales were facilitated through the internet, though at a very basic level. Email marketing, advertising, matrimonials and travel transactions were common on the internet. The exponential growth of the internet caused a change in the landscape we witness now.

Though IndiaPlaza.com can claim the first entrant title in the e-shopping scene, Flipkart popularised the segment throughout India, with several companies shooting off from its roots including Snapdeal, Myntra and Jabong. The huge success rate achieved by Flipkart alarmed Amazon, who made their way into the Indian market shortly followed by eBay. Alibaba's entry was more or less predictable and inevitable by then. However, none of this explains the mention of 'flash sale' in the title.

To understand the concept of flash sales, we have to go back to the entry of a certain Chinese smartphone manufacturer into the Indian market. The wide variety of reasons that helps them rapidly design and produce advanced smartphones at drop-dead prices also meant that they needed exciting marketing strategies to keep the customers coming back. A Flash Sale is one such marketing strategy conceptualised to rapidly sell products and generate a demand-supply gap in the market, in layman's terms, it is a bait to hook you in.

Although introduced by various TVC sales channels, Xiaomi, the first Chinese smartphone maker to make it big in India, popularised the concept of flash sales on online retail here. Rather than selling products the conventional way, they sell their products at pre-announced times, only to pre-registered users and only for a short period of time. This created hype and chain of marketing that quickly propelled the company to the top three ranks in the country. They made users wait for their product, rather than push it onto them, thus changing the way sellers and buyers interacted. This was also a great strategy for e-commerce platforms. As their traffic increased, so did the sale of other products they sold.

Following in their footsteps, more smartphone manufacturers started conducting flash sales. Xiaomi was followed by Huawei, Oppo, OnePlus, Vivo and the likes. They sold their products in large numbers. They couldn't